

Reshaping India's Political Map

From the 13th to the 17th centuries — invasions, sultanates, empires that rose and fell, and the many kingdoms that resisted. A story of destruction *and* resilience.

The one-line story

Between the 11th and 17th centuries (the later "medieval" period), waves of invaders from beyond the Hindu Kush — mostly **Turkic and Afghan** — reshaped India's map. The **Delhi Sultanate** (5 dynasties) rose and shrank; the **Vijayanagara Empire** flourished in the south; the **Mughals** built a mighty empire. Everywhere, regional powers — **Rajputs, Ahoms, Sikhs** and others — resisted. Politically unstable, but economically prosperous, India survived through **the sword and through fresh creation in art and spirit**.

What "medieval" means here: the term came from European history; for this book it simply means the **11th to 17th centuries** in India.

Dates that are worth memorising

Year	Event
1192	Defeat of Prithviraj Chauhan → leads to the Delhi Sultanate
1206	Establishment of the Delhi Sultanate
1336	Establishment of the Vijayanagara Empire (Harihara & Bukka)
1347	Establishment of the Bahmani Sultanate
1398	Timur attacks Delhi
1498	Arrival of the Portuguese in India
1526	First Battle of Panipat — Babur defeats Ibrahim Lodi → Mughal Empire begins
1556	Second Battle of Panipat — Akbar's decisive victory (over Hemu)
1565	Battle of Talikota — destruction of Vijayanagara city
1576	Battle of Haldighati — Maharana Pratap forced to retreat
1671	Battle of Saraighat — Ahoms (Lachit Borphukan) defeat the Mughals
1699	Formation of the Khalsa by Guru Gobind Singh
1799	Establishment of the Sikh Empire (Ranjit Singh)

The Delhi Sultanate — five dynasties

Formed after the defeat of **Prithviraj Chauhan (1192)**, the Sultanate saw **five successive Turkic-Afghan dynasties**:

Mamluks (Slave) → Khiljis → Tughlaqs → Sayyids → Lodis

Memory hook: "My Kind Teacher Says Learn" = Mamluk, Khilji, Tughlaq, Sayyid, Lodi.

- **Instability:** nearly 2 out of 3 sultans seized power by killing their predecessor — average reign was barely **9 years**.
- **Ala-ud-din Khilji:** raided north & central India, repelled **Mongol** invasions, called himself "the second Alexander" (Sikander Sani). His general **Malik Kafur** pushed south.
- **Muhammad bin Tughlaq:** for the first time since the Mauryas most of the subcontinent came under one ruler. Two failed schemes: shifting the capital to **Daulatabad** (people forced to walk 1,000+ km) and **token currency** (cheap copper coins declared equal to silver/gold → counterfeiting → economic decline).
- **Timur (1398):** a brutal Turkic-Mongol conqueror sacked Delhi and left with huge plunder. Afterwards the **Lodis** — the last Sultanate dynasty — emerged, but the territory had shrunk.

Def → **Jizya** = a tax imposed on non-Muslim subjects; **Iconoclasm** = destruction of religious images.

Resistance to the Delhi Sultanate

Who	Where	Highlight
Eastern Gangas (Narasimhadeva I)	Kalinga (Odisha)	Repelled the Sultanate; built the Konark Sun temple
Musunuri Nayakas	Warangal (Telangana)	United 75+ chieftains; expelled Tughlaq's army (~1330–36)
Hoysalas	Karnataka	Fended off attacks; built Belur & Halebidu temples; later merged into Vijayanagara
Rana Kumbha	Mewar (Rajasthan)	Built the 36-km-walled Kumbhalgarh Fort

Hoysala name legend: "Hoy (strike)! Sala" — young Sala struck a lion to save his guru.

The Vijayanagara Empire (est. 1336)

- Founded by brothers **Harihara and Bukka** at **Hampi** (guided by guru **Vidyaranya**) after they rejected Delhi's authority.

- Rival to the north: the **Bahmani Sultanate**, which later split into the five **Deccan Sultanates** — Bijapur, Golconda, Berar, Ahmednagar, Bidar.
- **Krishnadevaraya** (16th c.) = greatest ruler; military power + cultural renaissance. Wrote the Telugu epic **Āmuktamālyada**; patronised Sanskrit, Telugu, Kannada; granted temples (Tirupati, Vitthala).
- **Domingo Paes**, a Portuguese traveller, described the city as "as large as Rome... the best provided city in the world."
- **1565 — Battle of Talikota**: the Deccan Sultanates' coalition defeated Vijayanagara (led by Ramaraya); the city was sacked and ruined. The empire fragmented under the **Nayakas**.

"**Pati**" titles: Vijayanagara kings = **Narapati** (lord of men), Bahmani = **Ashwapati** (lord of horses), Marathas = **Chhatrapati** (lord of the parasol/crown).

The Mughals — Babur to Aurangzeb

Ruler	Remember for
Babur	Turkic-Mongol, descendant of Timur; won 1st Panipat (1526) using gunpowder & cannons → founded the Mughal Empire. Wrote the Baburnama .
Humayun	Lost ground to Sher Shah Suri (Sur Empire, many reforms) but reconquered it.
Akbar	Emperor at 13; brutal early (Chittor massacre) then tolerant — abolished jizya , promoted sulh-i-kul ("peace with all"), Rajput marriage alliances, "house of translation" at Fatehpur Sikri.
Jahangir	Loved art; had Guru Arjan tortured to death.
Shah Jahan	Builder of the Taj Mahal ; peak of art & architecture (Red Forts, Humayun's tomb).
Aurangzeb	"Alamgir"; imprisoned his father, killed brothers; empire's greatest extent but spent 25 years fighting in the Deccan → treasury drained. Re-imposed jizya ; destroyed temples; executed Guru Tegh Bahadur.

Average reigns: Delhi sultans ≈ 9 years; Mughal emperors up to Aurangzeb ≈ 27 years; all Mughals ≈ 16 years — longer reigns meant more stability.

Def → **Jauhar** = Rajput women's act of self-immolation to avoid capture (e.g. at Chittorgarh under Akbar).

Resistance to the Mughals — the great defenders

Group / Hero	Region	Why famous
Rani Durgavati	Garha (Gond, central India)	Fought Akbar's general (1564); took her own life to avoid capture
Maharana Pratap	Mewar	

		Battle of Haldighati (1576) ; then guerrilla war from the Aravallis; backed by Bhil archers
Rana Sanga	Mewar	United Rajput clans; lost to Babur at Khanwa
Ahoms (Lachit Borphukan)	Brahmaputra Valley (Assam)	Battle of Saraighat (1671) : 10,000 Ahoms beat 30,000 Mughals; paik system
Sikhs (Gurus → Ranjit Singh)	Punjab	Guru Nanak's Ik Onkār ; Guru Tegh Bahadur martyred (1675); Khalsa (1699); Sikh Empire (1799)

Ik Onkār = "there is one God for all." Sikh sacred text = **Guru Granth Sahib** (first compiled by Guru Arjan). Guru Tegh Bahadur stood up for Kashmiri Pandits and was beheaded at Chandni Chowk — marked by **Gurudwara Sis Ganj Sahib**.

Def → **Guerrilla warfare** = small groups using terrain knowledge for surprise attacks to beat bigger armies (used by Maharana Pratap & the Ahoms).

Def → **Paik system** (Ahoms) = every able-bodied man gave labour/military service in exchange for land — a large force without a permanent army.

Administering India — the systems

System	Under whom	What it was
Iqta system	Delhi Sultanate	Land (iqta) assigned to nobles (iqtdars) to collect taxes for the Sultan's treasury; posts not hereditary
Mansabdari system	Akbar	Officers ranked by mansab ; kept a fixed number of troops/horses; paid via land (jagir) → also called jagirdars
Four ministers	Akbar	Diwan (finance), Mir Bakhshi (military), Khan-i-Saman (works/trade/household), Sadr (justice & religion) across 12 subahs (provinces)
Revenue reform	Todar Mal (Akbar's finance minister)	Surveyed land & crop yields; fixed crop prices → stronger revenue

Abul Fazl wrote the **Ain-i-Akbari** describing Akbar's administration.

People's Lives — the economy

- Despite instability, India stayed one of the world's **wealthiest regions** — agrarian base, artisan industries, temple economies, wide trade.
- **Agriculture** = mainstay; land revenue usually **one-fifth** of produce (some sultans took up to one-half).
- Craft & trade: textiles, ship-building; exports through **Calicut, Surat, Masulipatnam, Hooghly, Mangalore**. India exported more than it imported.

- **Śhreṇis** = guilds; **jātis** = professional communities. **Hundi** = a written payment instruction (early banking) letting merchants move money without carrying cash. **Marwaris** traded across regimes.
- **Temples** were economic hubs — markets, credit, dāna (donations), dharmashālās & chhatrams for pilgrims.
- **But:** late 1600s saw stress — peasants kept a small share after taxes; many became bonded labourers; famines depended on the ruler's benevolence.

Model answers — write them like this

Example A. "Why did kingdoms like Vijayanagara and the Ahoms resist conquest longer than others?" [3]

Geo: Difficult terrain — hills, forests and rivers (Aravallis, Brahmaputra Valley) — made invasion hard.

Military: Smart tactics: Ahoms used guerrilla warfare & the paik system; Vijayanagara had strong armies and forts.

Social: Strong leadership & unity (Lachit Borphukan; Harihara–Bukka) and local support.

∴ Geography + tactics + united leadership let them hold out far longer.

Example B. "How did Akbar change from a ruthless conqueror to a tolerant ruler?" [5]

Early: As a young king he was brutal — the 5-month siege and massacre at Chittor (~30,000 civilians).

Shift: As he grew in knowledge he felt it wrong to force his faith on others ("what constancy from proselytes on compulsion?").

Policies: Abolished jizya, promoted **sulh-i-kul**, Rajput marriage alliances, Hindu officials, interfaith dialogues, "house of translation."

Result: A more stable, expanded empire with wide support, even from many Rajputs.

∴ Experience + strategy turned military might into tolerance-based statecraft.

Don't mix these up

Panipat confusion: 1st Panipat (1526) = Babur vs Ibrahim Lodi (Mughal Empire begins). **2nd Panipat (1556)** = Akbar (via Bairam Khan) vs Hemu.

Talikota (1565) destroyed **Vijayanagara**. **Haldighati (1576)** = Maharana Pratap. **Saraighat (1671)** = Ahoms win.

- Konark Sun temple = **Narasimhadeva I** (Eastern Gangas). Belur/Halebidu = **Hoysalas**. Kumbhalgarh = **Rana Kumbha**.
- Iqta (Sultanate) vs Mansabdari (Akbar). Todar Mal = revenue. Abul Fazl = Ain-i-Akbari.
- Ik Onkār = one God. Khalsa = 1699, Guru Gobind Singh.

→ Practise on the Worksheet, then check the Answer key.